

BRICS summit sets stage for China's digital push

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India was able to usher through a joint statement at the BRICS summit in New Delhi despite the conflict in the Middle East. Meanwhile, China outlined |||||

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What Happened

India hosted the 18th BRICS summit from 11 to 13 September and secured a joint statement despite the participation of three parties to the Middle East conflict: Iran, the UAE, and associate member Saudi Arabia. Also at the summit, India and China continued modest efforts to repair relations, while China outlined plans to advance its digital standards during its BRICS presidency next year.

Our Take

The summit produced rare diplomatic engagement between Iran and the UAE. India's baseline goal was to issue a joint statement, something that had eluded an earlier BRICS foreign ministers' meeting owing to the hostility between Iran and the UAE. Indian diplomats were able to persuade the two to agree to language that criticized Israel by name for military action against Lebanon and expressed concerns about strikes on nuclear targets, but only those under international safeguards. "Aggression" was criticized in generic terms but without naming the US.

India also sought to avoid provoking President Donald Trump, who has often denounced the BRICS, at a time when the US-India relationship is relatively stable (see: [US and India in no hurry to finalize trade deal](#) , 9 September 2026). New Delhi appears to have been successful, as Trump seemed to ignore the summit.

India and China will continue to pursue detente amid deep distrust. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Xi Jinping held a bilateral meeting during the summit. Xi called for the two countries to view each other as "partners, not rivals" and "opportunities, not threats," a sentiment guardedly reciprocated by Modi. Beijing sees a chance to dilute New Delhi's recent strategic tilt toward Washington. The two countries have taken modest steps to normalize relations, but there is almost no trust (see: [Underlying distrust will limit impact of India-China border announcement](#) , 28 August 2026).

India will struggle to block Chinese attempts to define BRICS digital standards. A long-term Indian goal has been to ensure the BRICS did not move toward centralized financial and trade integration that would enhance China's already dominant position in the grouping. At this summit, however, India notably failed to secure support for linking BRICS digital payment systems through a network of bilateral agreements.

Xi also outlined an agenda for China's BRICS presidency next year. He announced plans for a BRICS digital ecosystem cloud, an open-source AI community, an intelligent manufacturing initiative, and engineering training in all these areas for member states. Indian officials privately accept that New Delhi will struggle to resist China's use of the BRICS to legitimize the spread of Chinese platforms and standards, especially at a time when US credibility in the Global South is so low. That dynamic will make the BRICS summit in China in 2027 more consequential.

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